

Jobs

Why Europe is good for British jobs



Environment

Working with other countries to cut pollution



Britain

Your rights - and giving you a say



European Elections 2004

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Liberal Democrat Manifesto



Manifesto

MAKING EUROPE WORK FOR YOU

The Liberal Democrat Manifesto for the 2004 Elections to the European Parliament



INSIDE: The Liberal Democrat programme for Europe Contact us: www.libdems.org.uk



The Liberal Democrats tell it like it is. We don't scaremonger about Europe. But neither are we supine in our attitude towards Europe.

We should see the European Union for what it is: a way of tackling shared problems, upholding shared values, settling disputes between traditionally fractious neighbours and applying the rule of law to agreements that have been entered into.

Through the European Union, Britain can exercise real influence over the global economy and over international problems we can't deal with alone - like terrorism and organised crime.

Good for employment

The EU enhances trade within the European single market. That is good for British jobs and British industry. By enforcing competition within the single market, the EU helps make the products in our shops cheaper. That is good for all of us.

Acting as a trading bloc with other EU nations gives Britain a better opportunity to promote free trade with the richest nations and fair trade with developing nations.

Good for the environment

Environmental problems, such as pollution and climate change, do not respect arbitrary national boundaries. The only meaningful response must be a collective one.

Of course the EU isn't perfect, neither is Westminster. But reform can only come from within.

That is why Liberal Democrats are committed to improving the EU, attacking waste and inefficiency, reforming the unfair Common Agricultural and Common Fisheries Policies.

And we are working to make the EU more democratic and responsive to you, the people who it exists to serve.

Where European action isn't necessary, it should be left to member states to decide how to tackle their own problems.

That is why we are committed to Britain maintaining a national veto on fundamental constitutional issues - the right of the House of Commons to decide if British troops are ever sent into military conflict, budgetary and taxation matters, and regulations over pay and social security.

That is what this manifesto is about. Enhancing the good things Europe does for us, and reforming Europe, setting out better ways we can tackle the problems that all of us in Europe are facing.

Good for you

Liberal Democrat MEPs have proven themselves to be the most active and effective of your representatives in Europe. This manifesto shows some of the successes they have had.

Take a look at our proposals and you will see how a positive approach to Europe, the Liberal Democrat approach, can make a real difference for people in Britain.

Charles Kennedy

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Applicability

This document contains Federal Liberal Democrat policy, but there may be some issues on which policy of the Scottish and Welsh Liberal Democrats applies.

Lib Dem MEPs:

Liberal Democrat Members of the European Parliament are a growing and successful force. The first 2 Lib Dem MEPs were elected in 1994, and now there are 11. Liberal Democrat MEPs have been working hard to make Europe work for you since they were elected in 1999. In every area of the country they have been working hard to make a difference to the lives of their constituents.

They have battled to make sure that the EU tackles the needs of British people and promotes their interests, and that the EU works to help people who are suffering in every corner of the world.

In London:

Sarah Ludford has been MEP for London since 1999. Conscious that Londoners live in the most diverse city in Europe, Sarah has fought hard as European Liberal Democrat spokeswoman on justice and human rights for EU measures to deliver to all people equal respect and the right to live in secure communities.



She has tackled discrimination by shaping EU-wide legislation to outlaw discrimination not only against women but also against ethnic and religious minorities, gay people and older people, so that everyone in London can enjoy equality. Sarah has also pushed EU ministers to agree a common EU asylum system, so that all countries meet their obligations fairly. While London benefits hugely from the variety of people who come to live and work there, there are costs too, and these must be shared.

In the East of England:

Andrew Duff has been MEP for the Eastern Region since 1999. He is spokesman for the European Liberal Democrat group on constitutional affairs, and lead Liberal member for the group in the Convention



on the Future of Europe.

A leading federalist, he also represented the European Parliament in the Convention that drafted the Charter of Fundamental Rights in 1999-2000.

Andrew has pioneered political and institutional reform of the EU, to make it stronger, more efficient and democratic.



Sarah Ludford has:

- fought for Londoners suffering injustice abroad such as the British planespotters who were falsely convicted of spying in Greece, and promoted legislation at EU level to guarantee fair trial rights across Europe.
- successfully insisted that a third runway at Heathrow could not be built in breach of strict EU air and noise pollution limits, and that EU transport legislation should accommodate the specific safety requirements of London Underground.

Andrew Duff has:

- worked for improved links between the EU and Turkey, to encourage Turkey's human rights record and to enhance its democracy.
- campaigned to make the East of England Europe's top region for science and technology, building its research capacity and raising its profile.
- been active in helping to ensure the success of large-scale environmental conservation projects in the East of England. He is keen to limit the size of Stansted airport's expansion by applying strict environmental and competition policies, and by focusing the airport's future on serving the region's interests.

working hard for you

Liberal Democrat MEPs believe that it is the responsibility of the EU to look beyond the boundaries of Europe, to ensure that British concerns about the rest of the world have a strong voice through the EU. Liberal Democrat MEPs recognise, however, that the EU's first priorities must be the needs and concerns of its own citizens. Liberal Democrat MEPs have very different expertise, and as a team they represent the whole range of British interests. Here are just some of the things British Liberal Democrats have been doing in Europe since 1999.



Graham Watson has:

- made all the countries in the EU more secure against terrorism, by strengthening police co-operation over the arrest of terrorists. Graham piloted the legislation for a European Arrest Warrant through Parliament and helped to frame other legislation boosting the EU's defences against terrorism.
- led action in Parliament, and in the courts, to secure the right of football fans to buy match tickets on the open market.
- helped businesses in the South West by helping to secure the direction over £10m of funds from the EU budget into support for small businesses.

Diana Wallis has:

- made sure that justice is accessible to everyone in cross-border cases. Too often when a case crosses country borders, one side or the other does not get fair treatment. People can end up having their case tried in another country, where they may not understand the system.
- helped to make sure that all EU citizens will be able to bring claims in their local court, where they speak the language and understand the processes.

In the South West:

Graham Watson
Lib Dem MEP for South West England and
Leader of the European Liberal Democrat Group
in the European Parliament



Graham Watson has been an MEP in the South West since 1994. He has served on the European Parliament's Economic and Monetary Affairs Committee, the Budgets Committee, and was chair of the Committee on Citizens' Freedoms and Rights, Justice and Home Affairs. He now leads the European Liberal Democrat group in the Parliament. He has secured better public access to official EU documents than ever before. It is only right that the people of the EU should be able to understand all that the EU does, so that people and institutions can be held properly to account. Graham led the negotiations to achieve the recent Freedom of Information legislation.

In Yorkshire and the Humber:

Diana Wallis has been MEP for Yorkshire and the Humber since 1999. She is particularly interested in legal affairs and the internal market. She is on the EU delegation to maintain links with Switzerland, Iceland and Norway, the countries which are part of western Europe but are not members of the EU.



Diana's work has included highlighting the harassment of cross-channel shoppers. Innocent shoppers who take the ferry to France to buy their goods can be branded smugglers by customs officers. Diana has worked with her colleagues to highlight this problem, and to defend the interests of people who want to choose where they shop.

Diana Wallis, Lib Dem MEP for Yorkshire and the Humber and Leader of the UK Lib Dem MEPs

In the North East:

Fiona Hall stood as a European candidate in 1999 and at present works as Senior Parliamentary Researcher for Berwick MP Rt Hon Alan Beith.



Fiona Hall has:

- campaigned for many years on environmental issues in the region, helping to stop nuclear power and sand extraction at Druridge Bay and fighting against US 'ghost ships' being dumped on Teesside.

- taught in a squatter settlement in Botswana and is currently on the Liberal Democrat International Development Working Group.
- highlighted the Government's inefficient implementation of European legislation on hazardous waste sites and garden pesticides, which has created the danger of toxic dumping.

In Wales:

John Williams is a proficient linguist and political lobbyist. He is the son of a Monmouthshire farmer who has many years of professional experience in running a medical translation business and has worked as a freelance public affairs consultant in Brussels.



John Williams,
Welsh
Liberal Democrats



- A veteran environmental campaigner, John was called as a scientific witness to the BSE Inquiry in 1998.

- John will work to cut unnecessary EU red tape and campaign vigorously against the habitual gold-plating of EU directives by the British Government that has disadvantaged people in Britain severely compared to their European neighbours.

A record of action:

In the North West:

Chris Davies has been MEP for the North West since 1999, and before that was a Westminster MP. He is the European Liberal Democrats' spokesman on the environment and consumer affairs, serving on the committee responsible for 40% of all the EU legislation determined by the co-decision procedure that gives MEPs equal rights with ministers to amend and challenge law-making proposals.



Working For You

Chris Davies has:

- promoted measures to cut emissions of global warming gases, helping to close loopholes in plans for an EU-wide emissions trading scheme and ensure that the rest of Europe can learn from existing British experience.
- worked to achieve better air and water quality by steering through the European Parliament legislation to reduce the consequences of ozone pollution and got the

rules changed to make targets for cutting pollution mandatory.

- helped steer through new laws to require recycling of all waste electrical products, and to protect printer cartridge recyclers from unfair practices by multinational manufacturers.
- given governments new powers to curb smoking by introducing legislation that will, later this year, allow EU member states to support warnings on cigarette packs with stark visual images of the health consequences of smoking.

Working For You

Elspeth Attwooll has:

- successfully brokered a compromise on the provision of EU money for modernisation of fishing boats. As Rapporteur, Elspeth proposed a compromise, adopted by fisheries ministers, that would maintain a certain amount of flexibility for under 12 metre vessels, allowing them to make safety improvements even if that would result in a slight capacity increase. The same flexibility was not made available to larger vessels. Unfortunately the UK government has been less willing than others to take advantage of such funding opportunities.
- ensured that new rules on beef labelling would be workable. Elspeth deleted

from the Commission's Proposal a requirement to include animal category information on Europe-wide beef labels. If the requirement had not been deleted, it would now be obligatory to separate beef into batches according to category (heifer, bull, cow or steer) throughout the beef production chain.

- won protection for unique coral reefs off the North West coast of Scotland. Following pressure from Elspeth Attwooll on the European Commission and British Government, emergency measures were adopted to save the Darwin Mounds coral reefs from the destructive impact of sea bottom trawling. Around 300 different species, including many deep-sea fish, depend on the mounds for their survival. Elspeth guided through the European Parliament the measure making this permanent.



In the East Midlands:

Bill Newton Dunn,
Lib Dem MEP for the East Midlands

Bill Newton Dunn represented Lincolnshire as an MEP from 1979-1994 and the East Midlands since 1999. He joined the Liberal Democrats from the Conservatives in 2000 because of the Conservatives' ever-increasing anti-European attitude. He is a full member of the Parliament's Justice & Home Affairs committee and an alternate member of the Industry & Trade committee. He has the best attendance record at the Parliament of all British MEPs since 1999 and will have the greatest experience of all British MEPs standing again for election on June 10th.

Bill Newton Dunn has worked to ensure a faster EU response to humanitarian disasters. It is important that the EU works to help people in need across the world, and this includes being ready to act when a disaster occurs. Bill has put forward recommendations about exactly how the rapid reaction force should work to make sure that it is as effective as possible.



Nick Clegg has been MEP for the East Midlands since 1999. He is now the Trade and Industry spokesman for the Liberal Democrat group in the European Parliament. He has worked on numerous EU laws of importance to British business, especially in the telecoms, energy and transport fields. He has also written extensively on EU issues ranging from European education systems to global trade.

Nick has also improved the quality of EU laws, by negotiating a new set of rules which mean that all proposed EU laws have to be properly tested. By investigating the impact laws will have before they come into force, we can make sure that the laws do what they are supposed to do.

In Scotland:

Elspeth Attwooll has been MEP for Scotland since 1999; before that she was a lecturer at Glasgow University. She is the European Liberal Democrats' Spokesperson on employment and social affairs and is also a member of both the fisheries and agriculture committees.

She pushed for greater equality of opportunities in the labour market. She has campaigned for specific measures to deal with the problems faced by people in particular sectors of the labour market, such as those not in typical working relationships, women in rural areas and women returning to work.



Working For You

Bill Newton Dunn has:

- worked to secure citizens' rights across the EU as a member of the Committee on Citizens' Freedoms and Rights, Justice and Home Affairs.
- campaigned for businesses in the East Midlands. One example was by calling on the Commission to grant to Melton Mowbray the same protection of its name and regional status as it has granted to the producers of Champagne and Stilton cheese with regard to the making of the traditional, world-famous pork pies.
- represented East Midlands residents who have been treated badly by officials in other countries when travelling in the EU.

Nick Clegg has:

- helped to draft legislation, boosting environmentally friendly heat and power facilities, many of which are manufactured in the East Midlands, so helping to support local jobs whilst protecting the environment.
- campaigned to secure EU regional funds for the East Midlands, by arranging a high profile visit by the EU's top official dealing with EU regional funds to the East Midlands, his first to a region in the UK outside of London. This ensured that the needs of the East Midlands were well understood at the highest levels in Brussels.
- helped to stop another Foot and Mouth disaster, by being involved in the only public independent enquiry into the disaster, which had a profound effect on the rural areas in the East Midlands and across the country. He has taken part in drafting EU recommendations to improve future contingency planning.

Working with Europe

In the South East:

Chris Huhne has been MEP for the South East since 1999. Before that he was an economist and a journalist. He is particularly interested in financial issues, and works hard to promote British interests. He is the European Liberal Democrats' member on the European Parliament's Economic and Monetary Affairs Committee, and so he monitors the work of the European Central Bank.

Chris (*below, left*) has stopped bureaucratic rules that threatened British jobs, such as the ban on selling barley straw mats to cut pond algae that would have put local South East manufacturer Greenways out of business.



Emma Nicholson has been an MEP for the South East since 1999. She has wide experience of international development work, and has concentrated her work in the European Parliament on ensuring that the EU has a positive role in supporting developing countries.

Emma has promoted human rights around the world. She is the Vice Chair of the European Parliament's Committee for Foreign Affairs, Human Rights, Common Defence and Security Policy and frequently chairs the Human Rights working group. She is also the UN World Health Organisation's Special Envoy working for Health as a tool for Peace and Development.

She has a special commitment to the Islamic world, and she has helped the Iraqi people to start to rebuild their country and to increase access to clean water and healthcare across the region. Last year she was awarded the unique honour of 'MEP of the Year' for her work undercover in Taliban-controlled Afghanistan by a global poll of over 70 countries. Emma worked with Eastern European states to help them towards membership of the EU within the enlargement process. As Rapporteur, Emma has responsibility for monitoring and assisting in Romania's progress towards joining the EU. She has battled to ensure that potential Member States meet the stringent entry requirements before they are allowed to join the EU and has particularly campaigned against corruption, for the rule of law, justice for ordinary citizens and children's rights.



Emma Nicholson, Lib Dem MEP for the South East and winner, MEP of the year award

The text of the Liberal Democrat Manifesto is available from our website at: www.libdems.org.uk
Copies are also available in large print, on tape and in Braille from:
Liberal Democrats, 4 Cowley Street, London SW1P 3NB. Tel: 020 7222 7999
Email: info@libdems.org.uk



Chris Huhne has:

- put a 'sunset clause' into EU regulations for the first time, so that powers given to the EU Commission will be removed after four years if they are abused or do not have the desired effect.
- reduced the cost of new finance for expanding businesses by establishing one set of information for all member states when companies issue shares or bonds (the 'prospectus directive').
- fought against unfair state aids to move jobs from the South East, notably the Italian government subsidy to transfer Pirelli jobs from Hampshire to Naples.



Emma Nicholson has:

- promoted environmental issues, organic farming, and accurate labelling of food products. Emma has supported a wide range of environmental measures and has encouraged and assisted local campaigns in the South East.
- worked with Kent Police, Scotland Yard and Interpol to uncover and combat child pornography on the internet and child trafficking. As well as working directly on the ground to fight the abuse of children in the UK and abroad, Emma has worked relentlessly at the EU and international level to ensure the implementation of new legislation that protects the rights of children.

In the West Midlands:

Liz Lynne has been MEP for the West Midlands since 1999, and before that was a Westminster MP.

She is particularly interested in employment legislation and social affairs, and is on the Employment and Social Affairs Committee. She has campaigned for equal rights for people with disabilities and others across the EU.

Liz Lynne has made EU legislation more practical. Liz ensured that industry would not be harmed by directives on the acceptable levels of vibrations and noise, while still protecting the workforce.

She also made sure that the vibrations directive took more account of the needs of the agricultural sector by extending the amount of hours a tractor could be driven, although it is still not ideal, and that the noise directive recognised the special characteristics of the leisure and entertainment industry.

This saved businesses and workers in the West Midlands and throughout Britain from extra costs or possible loss of jobs.



Liz Lynne has:

- helped make it illegal to discriminate at work on the basis of age. In recent years many people made redundant as they approach retirement, have found it difficult to get new jobs, and many others who wanted to keep working beyond a standard retirement age found that it was difficult for them to do so. Liz has made sure that employment legislation includes banning employers from discriminating on the basis of age.
- tackled discrimination on the grounds of disability. Liz wrote the reports for the

European Parliament on both the European Year of People with Disabilities 2003 and one calling for a legally binding UN Convention on the rights of disabled people.

● campaigned against airport expansion in the West Midlands. She was involved in the successful campaign which opposed a new airport near Rugby, and continues to fight proposed expansion at Coventry and Wolverhampton, and against a second runway at Birmingham airport.

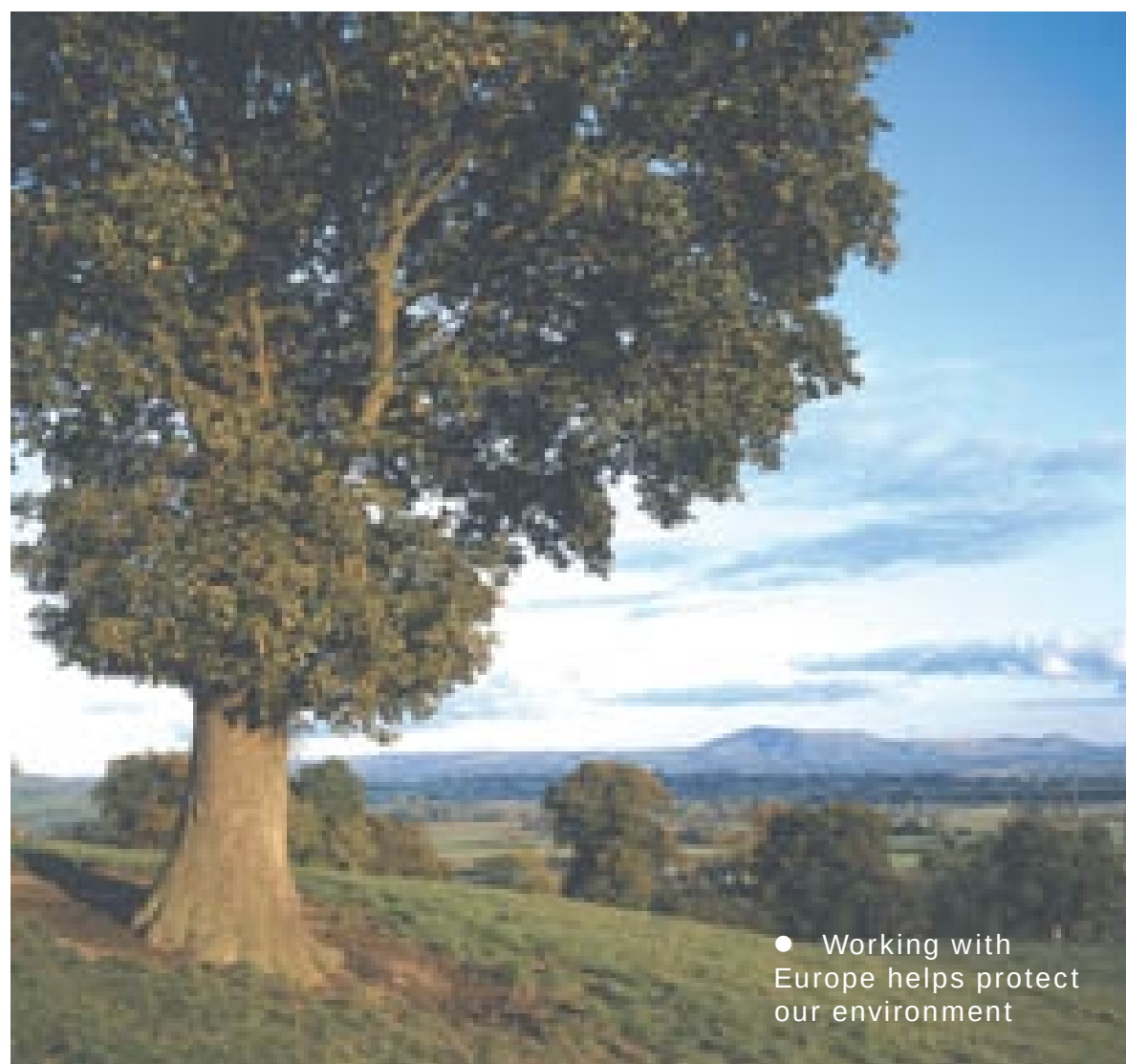
● campaigned against the French ban on British beef, which hit farmers in the West Midlands particularly hard. Liz highlighted the issue by carrying prime Herefordshire beef through French customs at Strasbourg Airport.

What Europe has achieved for Britain

European unity is good for Britain. Although the European Union needs to be more open, democratic and decentralised, the participation of Britain in the European Union ensures our long-term peace, security and prosperity. Since 1973 EU membership has helped to modernise Britain and to widen our horizons. This year's enlargement to 25 member countries expands the single market and projects the security and stability we have enjoyed further east and south.

In many cases working with other countries within the EU is just far more effective than working alone. On issues such as the environment or cross-border crime, only international action can tackle problems which cross international borders.

Here are some reasons why Britain is made more powerful and more successful by working through the EU.



● Working with Europe helps protect our environment

Achieving for Trade and Jobs:

Trade and employment are two of the biggest areas of work for the EU.

One of the main benefits of EU membership is to make it easier for European countries to trade with one another, and now the EU plays an important role in ensuring that all EU citizens have the freedom to work where they choose, without discrimination.

- The EU makes it easier for people to live and work in other European countries. The EU has ensured that British people who want to work in another EU country for a while can do that without losing their pension rights.

- The EU defends British people against discrimination in the workplace. New EU rules mean that no employer will be allowed to discriminate against people on the basis of their disability, age, religion or sexual orientation. This strengthens existing British rules against discrimination on the grounds of gender or race.

- The EU gives British shoppers the right to shop abroad

without excise duties. All British shoppers have the right to buy alcohol or tobacco from other EU countries and bring it back to the UK, free of excise duties. This means British citizens are more able to shop around for the best deal.

- The EU helps British families to get the right balance between home and work. The EU ruled that all mothers should be able to choose to take up to 18 weeks paid maternity leave, and that all parents should be entitled to 13 weeks paid parental leave during their child's first five years. This helps many British parents to juggle their family and work commitments.

Achieving for the Environment:

Even the most severe critic of the European Union knows that pollution does not stop at national borders.

An environmental disaster in one country can have implications for all the surrounding countries, and one country's unsustainable policies can mean that resources are taken from other countries. Multinational action is required to protect our



environment and ensure that resources are used sustainably. EU environment laws are building on best practice and new technology to raise standards for all.

- The EU takes the lead internationally in combating global warming. Europe stepped in and pulled the world together behind the need to fight climate change when the USA backed away from its responsibilities. Today the EU continues to lead by introducing practical measures to reduce greenhouse gas emissions.

- The EU has raised water and air quality standards across Britain, its environment laws providing the impetus to clean the beaches and herald the return of otters to our rivers and kingfishers to our cities. EU laws recognise the importance of protecting unique habitats and species for generations to come.

- EU rules force manufacturers to recycle equipment, taking the burden off taxpayers. Producers are being required to accept responsibility for providing for the recycling of their products, be they old vehicles, electrical waste, or packaging materials, thereby reducing the need for landfill.

Achieving Justice and Security:

Being able to live and work in other European countries brings us many benefits, but the free movement of people within the EU can make it easier for criminals to escape justice by fleeing to other countries, and it can mean that ordinary people do not have access to the justice they deserve because they are away from home. The EU has done a lot to tackle these problems.

- The EU helps to protect Britain from terrorism. Greater cross-border co-operation by police, prosecutors and judges makes it easier to combat major crimes such as terrorism. Police working together makes it easier for them to catch criminal gangs, and prosecutors and judges working together means that criminals can be brought to justice under any legal system.

- The EU makes sure that British people accused of a crime abroad get a fair trial. The EU has created a "letter of rights", which means that anyone who gets into trouble abroad will know what help and support they are entitled to get. This includes bail, legal aid and interpretation facilities.

- The EU works to stop smuggling and people trafficking. The EU is working towards common asylum and immigration rules across the EU, so that countries can work together to stop the smuggling of goods and people. This is a clear example of an area where one country alone cannot have as much of an impact.

- The EU protects British people who want to buy a timeshare holiday home abroad. Clearer rights for people buying property abroad, and safeguards against misleading advertising, would mean that fewer people will be ripped off. In particular, there is now a "cooling off" period on timeshares, helping consumers to discover if they have been the victims of a scam.

- The EU supports a wider education for all young people. Schemes such as the Erasmus Programme allow young people to study in other EU countries on exchange programmes. The EU also supports cultural ex-

changes with other continents, to build up global relations.

Achieving Peace and Influence Across the World:

The EU plays a major role in supporting peace and aid initiatives across the world. This makes the individual countries of the EU far more powerful than they could be on their own.

- Western Europe has spent over 50 years free from war. The EU was first set up to protect the fragile peace after the Second World War by encouraging trade between countries. In the

twenty-first century it still protects that peace, and promotes peace in other parts of the world.

- The EU is the world's largest donor of international aid. This gives Britain and the other countries of the EU far greater influence over world affairs than we would otherwise have.

- The EU works to support democracy and human rights in the former Communist states. People in this country take for granted the basic values of freedom and democracy. The EU is working across Central and Eastern Europe to support those val-

ues. Enlarging the EU by another ten states has helped to achieve this, making the world safer for all of us.

- European countries acting together on security and defence policy can help to make a greater contribution to our own security, and to act when the USA is not able to take a role. By ensuring that the armed forces of EU members are able to work together we are more able to respond to international crises where we have a shared interest, where the USA does not want to get involved.

‘Working with other countries is far more effective than working alone.... Britain is more successful by working with Europe ‘



How the European Union could work better

Liberal Democrats believe that Britain is much better off in the EU than outside it. But that doesn't mean we believe the EU is perfect.

Liberal Democrats recognise that the EU, like any system of government, can and should be improved. The EU has flaws and these flaws should be put right. It needs to be more open, more democratic, more decentralised, and more accountable. But Britain can have more influence in EU reform if it is at the centre of European affairs, working with other countries and putting our case.

No one wants an EU which is inefficient, undemocratic or removed from the concerns of real people. That's why Liberal Democrats are committed to trying to improve the EU, by building on its many strengths.

We welcome the draft Constitution drawn up by the European Convention in which Liberal Democrats played a key role. We have long argued that a Constitution is necessary to define and limit the powers of the European Union by clarifying the values, principles, and objectives of the Union, and so this fulfils long-standing Liberal Democrat objectives.

However, we are committed to maintaining a veto on fundamental constitutional issues, defence, the overall level of EU spending, national budgets and rates of tax, and social security. The current draft Constitution rationalises the instruments used by the EU, streamlines its decision-making procedures, limits its competences and strengthens its institutions. As such, it would make the EU's system of governance more open, democratic and efficient, while at the same time enhancing the capacity of the Union to act effectively at home and abroad.

That is why Liberal Democrats will campaign for the adoption of the draft Constitution, but we believe the choice ultimately lies with the British people in a referendum. Specific aspects of the draft Constitution which we

welcome include:

- **Institutional reform.**

The Council, like the Parliament, would have to pass laws in public. Stronger policy co-ordination within the Council in accordance with a medium-term strategy promises better law-making. The Committee of Regions would be able to ensure matters are dealt with at a national or local level when that would be more effective than EU-wide action. The financial and budgetary system of the Union would strike a good balance between the roles of the Council and the European Parliament. This would, for example, allow the Parliament to cut waste in agricultural spending.

- **Strengthening the elected European Parliament.**

Qualified majority voting in the Council and co-decision with the European Parliament would be the normal legislative procedure, with exceptions in certain areas. The European Parliament would have powers across the whole EU budget, including agriculture. The President of the Commission would be elected jointly by the European Council and European Parliament.

- **Protecting citizens' rights.**

The **Charter of Fundamental Rights** would be installed in the Constitution with mandatory effect. The acquisition of an international legal personality for the Union would also enable it to sign up to the existing European Convention on Human Rights.

- **Empowering individual citizens** through the introduction of a right of citizens' initiative, allowing citizens to initiate EU legislation.

- **Promoting co-operation on defence.** There would be more co-operation among certain member states that are both militarily capable and politically willing. The Union's security and defence dimension must complement and develop in close co-operation with NATO, and Britain should be in the forefront of the European defence effort, which should not undermine NATO. This will allow the EU to build on its work, for example, peacekeeping in the Former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia.

- **Promoting co-operation on foreign policy.** An EU Foreign Minister will chair the

Council of External Relations and be a Vice-President of the Commission, running a joint administration.

- **Giving national parliaments an important role in scrutinising EU law.** MPs would be enabled to check on all draft EU law for its accordance with the principle of 'subsidiarity', by which decisions are made at the most local effective level.

- **Strengthening the role of the European Court of Justice.** The Court would have more scope to act as a proper constitutional court, to enforce compliance with EU law and to hear cases brought by individual citizens.

Beyond the provisions of the draft Constitution, Liberal Democrat priorities will be:

- **Making sure that EU action does not go beyond what is needed to achieve specific objectives.**

By working more closely with the EU and scrutinising proposals before they become law, the British government should prevent legislation that is more powerful than intended and which has harmful effects.

Liberal Democrats remain committed to the principle of subsidiarity. Even on environmental matters, where transnational rules are so often required, decisions that will affect Britain, and Britain alone, should not be determined at an EU level.

- **Making sure that all EU laws are enforced consistently.**

Some countries are more rigorous in enforcing EU laws than others. National governments often agree to legislation but then fail to enforce it. This leads to unfair advantages for those countries which do not play by the rules. The French ban on British beef was one example of this. Liberal Democrats will press for the Commission to put more resources into making sure that the rules are consistently enforced.

- **Curbing bureaucracy by ensuring that all new legislation is subject to a fully independent regulatory impact assessment.**

This will help to stop the EU passing laws which may be useful in one country but damaging in another, or which





are complicated or difficult to enforce. This should go hand in hand with greater consultation of interested parties for all proposed EU legislation, including industry and civil society.

● **Making sure that decisions are taken as locally to the people concerned as is effective.**

Liberal Democrats believe that the EU should only act if it can add real value. That is why we support EU action in improving the environment or in fighting cross-border crime. On issues like road maintenance and schools, however, local people understand best what their area needs, and so power should rest with them. We also want to see greater decentralisation of the management of EU policies so as to ensure significant moves away from EU to national or regional bodies.

● **Ensuring that EU taxpayers' money is spent effectively by persistently and rigorously scrutinising expenditure.**

So we will continue to press the Commission and the Court of Auditors to provide the Parliament with much clearer financial management analysis, sector by sector, accompanied by measurable performance indicators, and to name and shame those Member States not fulfill-

‘Liberal Democrats will campaign for the adoption of the draft Constitution, but we believe the choice ultimately lies with the British people in a referendum’

ing their responsibility of protecting the Community's financial interests. Proper accounting procedures should be put in place. The main target of reform of the budget must be the Common Agricultural Policy, and reform of the budget which does not deal with the CAP is not reform.

● **Strengthening measures to tackle fraud against the EU budget.**

The EU's anti-fraud unit (OLAF) should be independent of the Commission and able to launch proactive investigations into fraud against the EU budget as and when necessary, as part of a wider EU pursuit of fraud against the budget.

● **Boosting the role of the nations and regions of the UK.**

Many parts of the UK have benefited from EU structural funds for regional and social development. But often Whitehall and the Treasury have interfered in these, and stopped them being so effective. To cut bureaucracy, management of these funds should be devolved to democratically elected bodies in the nations and regions concerned, because they understand best how to help their communities. The Scottish Parliament, the Assemblies in Wales and Northern Ireland and the future English regional assemblies deserve

a greater voice in the EU, and should be more directly represented over the issues that concern them.

● **Increasing the voice of Westminster MPs over EU proposals.**

The Prime Minister should appear before Parliament before going to European Council meetings, so that MPs can ask him about the agenda and he can explain his approach to those issues. Any other ministers attending the Council should likewise be held to account. After meetings there should be a similar scrutiny process, so that our democratically elected national MPs can hold our representatives on the Council to account. We will continue to oppose the practice of "gold-plating" where the British government adds unnecessary burdens regarding the implementation of EU laws. We also want to see more collaboration between MPs and MEPs, and an annual Europe Week in Westminster, where MPs scrutinise and debate the EU's programme for the year.

● **Reforming the European Central Bank.**

The ECB deserves credit for achieving a smooth transition from national currencies to the euro and for establishing a reputation for maintaining financial stability in the eurozone. But

its lack of flexibility, relative to the US Federal Reserve is in danger of stifling growth. Therefore, we want to see it taking decisions by majority vote. It should also publish its minutes and a record of its votes, following the practice of the Bank of England's Monetary Policy Committee, so that everyone can understand how its decisions are taken and why.

● **Stopping the expense and inconvenience of holding the Parliament in Brussels and Strasbourg.**

It wastes time and money for the Parliament to have to travel between Brussels and Strasbourg for its meetings. MEPs should have the right to decide where they want to meet, once and for all.

● **Stimulating hearts and minds as well as trade.**

The popularity of the EU does derive from people feeling that their culture is valued as much as their economic output. Therefore it is important that the EU properly supports the cultural activity that crosses several countries and so tends to be outside the usual programmes of individual nations. The EU must also take care that, in expanding the number of member countries, it does not close its gates to the cultures of others.

Trade and Jobs

From its earliest days a key task for the EU has been to make it easier for neighbouring European countries to trade with each other, and that remains at the heart of the EU today. Easier trade enhances prosperity and promotes peaceful relations.

Membership of the EU gives British companies a massive market of 455 million people, where they can compete on an equal basis with other European businesses. This is a big advantage, and contributes to many British jobs, and British prosperity in general.

In addition to this, by being involved in Europe, Britain can help set the standards for trade, and ensure that any standards set are fair. However, Britain does not play as leading a role in Europe as it should. Outside the euro, Britain's share of international investment has slumped. We need to work positively to achieve the conditions necessary for euro entry. Once those conditions for entry have been achieved, the British people should be allowed to make their decision about whether Britain should be in the euro or not, through a fair referendum.

Membership of the euro would bring many benefits to Britain. It would offer a sound basis for currency stability, end the terrible damage that high and fluctuating exchange rates with the rest of Europe do to British businesses, and end conversion costs. Half a million manufacturing and agricultural jobs have been lost since 1997 primarily because of the high value of the pound. Until Britain joins the euro these problems will continue to follow us, and British businesses will continue to be at a disadvantage in European markets. It's time for the British people to be given the chance to decide on the euro, one way or the other.

should work to reduce subsidies to industry. British businesses already receive fewer subsidies than businesses in other countries, and we would all benefit from a level playing field. This needs to include the EU taking tougher action on unfair monopolies.

- **Promoting genuinely liberal trade throughout the world.**

The EU should play a leading role in pushing multilateral liberalisation, balanced with social and environmental objectives, through the World Trade Organisation and other bodies. This needs to work to open up markets and provide real opportunities for growth of developing countries, by allowing them to sell their goods abroad.

To make sure this happens, the EU needs to reform its own bloated and inefficient trade distorting agricultural subsidy system as a matter of urgency. Then it will gain credibility and support in working to improve the transparency of the WTO and ensuring that environmental regulations are not undercut by WTO rules. National parliaments and the European Parliament should have a greater role scrutinising trade policy, with the European Parliament having the power of assent over WTO trade agreements - as provided for in the draft Constitution.

- **Working positively towards the conditions for British entry to the euro, so that the British people can decide whether to join through a referendum.**

It is important that the British people should be given a realistic choice about whether or not to join, to safeguard the investment in Britain of thousands of overseas firms, and to reduce the cost of trade with the rest of the EU. Put simply, being outside the euro will mean job losses and reduced prosperity, and will prevent the UK from gaining the influence that comes with being a member of such a significant international currency. Working towards euro entry is not a waste of time even if we decide not to go in. One of the conditions for entry is a stable and competitive exchange rate, and that is good for Britain in itself.

Boosting the economy, putting Britain in a strong position to trade with the rest of Europe and the rest of the world.

- **Making it easier for British businesses to trade in Europe.**

The single market has achieved a lot to make trading between countries easier, but there are still unnecessary trade barriers. There are many national regulations stopping people like financial advisors and architects from offering services across country borders. Britain excels in the financial services industry, but is not able to compete freely in the rest of Europe. Liberal Democrats support the efforts of the European Commission to create a single market in the EU financial services sector.

- **Promoting competition to boost prosperity.**

The EU's competition policy needs to be stronger and more proactive so that businesses have more opportunities to trade abroad. In particular, the EU



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'It's time for the British people to be given the chance to decide on the euro, one way or another'

- **Creating greater flexibility by reforming the Stability and Growth Pact so that the UK is more able to borrow for public investment.** The breakdown of the Stability and Growth Pact provides an opportunity to bring in a new regime for European fiscal policies. There needs to be a code of conduct to clarify how the Pact will be applied. This code needs to take account of the business cycle, should stress the roles of the Commission and the Council in ensuring that cyclical budget adjustments are made in boom years, and should be more flexible for countries such as Britain, that have low ratios of public debt to GDP. The 60% of GDP overall limit for debt is a more important figure than an annual budget one. So providing countries are within the 60% limit, the annual figure could be more flexible to take account of the business cycle.

- **Combating unemployment and increasing sustainable economic growth in line with the founding principles of the EU.** The European Union's policies should complement member states' efforts to promote competitiveness and create jobs through completion of the internal market and by enhancing labour market flexibility and labour mobility. At the same time, it is necessary to share best

practice across the EU about how to balance the competing demands of liberalisation, deregulation and tackling social exclusion.

Helping workers throughout the EU to live and work freely.

- **Enabling greater freedom for people to live and work throughout the EU.**

The EU has a vital role in ensuring that British and other EU citizens can move between countries whilst continuing to exercise their rights effectively. To this end, Liberal Democrats believe that there needs to be a single market for occupational pensions so that people can move between countries but take their pension rights with them. There also needs to be better access to justice in cross-border disputes. There should be judicial co-operation to assist citizens in cross-border civil disputes, particularly family disputes. This is an area where co-operation yields tangible benefits to individuals and discourages abuse through forum 'shopping'. There should also be common minimum standards relating to legal aid and other financial aspects of civil proceedings.

- **Recognise the value of EU work on employment, while not encroaching on the rights and responsibilities of member states.**

The EU has frequently led the way in protecting individual rights, for example relating to gender, age, race, disability, religion and sexual orientation. So we accept the need for a certain degree of employment legislation at the European level but do not think it is necessary for the EU to assume what are currently national responsibilities in this area.

The main responsibility for social policy should remain with the member states, with more exchange of best practice through the EU. Decisions should be taken as closely as possible to the citizen and should be sufficiently flexible to accommodate different national conditions. For this reason, social legislation should not be imposed on member states. We support 'voluntary opt outs' for legislation like the Working Time Directive, where there are distinct national differences.

- **Enhancing regional development policy.**

Regions and nations in the UK have been helped via the EU when they have been ignored by the UK government. However, regional policy in the EU needs to be simpler, even more decentralised, and better targeted. It should focus on the development of small and medium sized businesses, encourage enterprise, particularly in rural areas, increase investment in information networks, and foster inter-regional co-operation between different states.



Photo: Simon Rix



Protecting our Environment:

Pollution does not respect national borders. Problems such as climate change, acid rain or the threat to the ozone layer cannot be effectively tackled by nations acting alone. EU-wide co-ordinated action is vital and is proving effective.

The EU already has a good record on promoting high environment standards, sharing best practice amongst its members and setting binding targets. Almost all Britain's environment legislation is driven by the EU institutions and MEPs have very significant powers in this field.

But the EU must do more to protect our planet for future generations. The principles of sustainable development must be turned into practice both here and abroad. Harmful agricultural subsidies must be cut, while the EU must use for the good its influence over trade policies to ensure that nations everywhere look to meeting long term needs without causing irreversible damage to habitats and species.

European Union leadership has given hope to the world that the problem of climate change may be reduced. This role must be strengthened, and the EU must work equally hard within the WTO and other international organisations to demonstrate that high environmental standards will not act as a new form of trade protectionism against products from the developing world.

The enlargement of the EU creates new challenges. Environmental standards in former Soviet bloc member states are often in need of much improvement, although it must be admitted that there is still great disparity between the performance of members of longer standing. Priority must be given to the equal and effective enforcement of legislation, both to protect the environment and prevent distortions in economic competition. Environmental targets must be realistic but must also remain ambitious.

Liberal Democrat priorities are:

Making the EU a true champion of the environment.

- **Helping the countries of the EU to use their influence in the world.**

The EU is a group of very powerful and wealthy countries, who can have a great deal of influence on global environmental policy, particularly when we work together. The EU should push to have much stronger environ-

mental factors included in the investment and lending policies of the WTO, IMF, the World Bank and regional development banks. The EU should be at the forefront of global climate negotiations to persuade other countries to ratify the Kyoto agreement and extend it. In the United Nations, the EU needs to argue for increased resources for the UN Environment Programme, and for the establishment of a UN Economic and Environmental Security Council for Sustainability. The EU needs to continue to work hard to eliminate environmental crime such as illegal trade in endangered species or in hazardous waste.

- **Putting the environment at the heart of Europe.**

The principle of sustainable development and environmental protection should be included in EU legislation as the new EU Constitution says. This would mean that all EU policies would be audited for their environmental impact, with the results reported to the democratically elected European Parliament. This would also mean that environmental objectives would be



built into relevant areas of EU policy, such as transport or the Common Agricultural Policy.

Making EU environmental action more effective.

- **Ensuring agreed environmental and animal welfare standards are better enforced and that environmental standards are higher.**
Britain has a mixed record on enforcing environmental standards that are agreed in the EU. However some other countries have different approaches to enforcement and as a result too many law abiding British businesses are put at a disadvantage because they have to meet costs which their competitors do not. The Commission needs to improve its application of the existing processes to deal with infringements, so that member states are fined after a first judgement against them, instead of having to wait for a second judgement. If there was a successful appeal, the fine could be returned. In the near future, the European Parliament must be particularly vigilant over the enforcement of the Birds and Habitats Directive, which will protect many of Britain's treasured natural species and habitats.

- **Making energy more sustainable.**

We welcome the Commission's decision to produce an Energy Services Directive, which will make sure that the very positive liberalisation of the energy market is balanced with environmental concerns. Liberal Democrats will argue for a strong Directive on this, and for

its proper implementation. We will work to ensure that the EU Commission's proposals on security of energy supplies make adequate provision for decentralised electricity grids and power production and sustainable energy sources.

- **Promote good environmental practice through markets.**

Financial and fiscal incentives can be a very effective way of encouraging markets to support environmentally friendly activities and reduce harmful ones. In order to cut CO₂ emissions, for example, there must be clear economic incentives for producers and consumers. Liberal Democrats will work with our European colleagues to agree a zero level of VAT on all energy conservation materials. We will ensure that the UK, in producing its allocation plan for permits in the mandatory phase of the EU emissions trading scheme beginning in 2008, will achieve real emissions reduction. The plan should also promote more efficient and carbon-free generation and use of energy, maintaining British industries' competitiveness. Only by working with markets can we have a real impact on these problems.

Supporting farming and fishing in a constructive way.

- **Replacing the Common Agricultural Policy with a Food and Rural Policy.**

Liberal Democrats support the interests of rural communities, family farms and the rural environment. However, the CAP does not do this effectively, and needs continuing reform. Moreover, the CAP is doing



- **Liberal Democrats support the EU's tough stance on regulating the licensing of GM crops.**

Building a Greener Europe

immense damage to developing countries, world trade and European budget priorities. The EU should gradually eliminate its food export subsidies and assist the balanced development of agriculture in the least developed countries. It should take the lead under the auspices of the WTO to eliminate trade distortion.

The mid-term review of the CAP has already started a much needed reduction in the burden placed on the EU budget, but it is vital that the freedom given to member states to direct farm funding is used by the UK government to best effect.

Any public funding should achieve public benefits. This should include long term strategies for maintaining the countryside, supporting wildlife, heritage and landscape, improving public access, giving additional support to extensive and organic farming, rewarding quality production, special protection for less favoured areas and grants to help small farmers remain viable by adding value or diversification. We put great priority in enabling farmers to switch from food production to that of biomass and biofuel.

- **Building a fisheries policy which protects regional fisheries and stock recovery.**

The Common Fisheries Policy is over-centralised, taking it too far away from those who work in the industry. The proposed Regional Advisory Councils are

positive, but they must give local fishermen a real say, working with scientists and regulators, over issues like quotas. Liberal Democrats will work to protect depleted fish stocks through more efficient techniques as well as better regulation, and will work to establish minimum sanctions across the EU for anyone who goes against these regulations. There needs to be particularly tough action for those who use techniques which endanger dolphins. Bilateral agreements between countries are generally positive, but Liberal Democrats would curb those agreements which currently allow EU fleets to overfish the waters of developing countries.

- **Using the EU so that problems like the foot and mouth disaster are less likely to happen again.**

Liberal Democrats would build on the EU's current work by encouraging collaboration between the UK Customs Service and other countries, at a national and EU level, to tackle the illegal import of animals and meat. We will also encourage best practice and training in biosecurity controls.

- **Making sure that decisions about whether to grow GM crops are taken using scientific evidence on the basis of the precautionary principle.**

Liberal Democrats resist commercial and political pressure to

hurry the decision-making process on this. There are legitimate concerns about the commercialisation of GM crops, and about a few multi-national biotech companies exerting too much control over worldwide practices. We support the EU's tough stance on regulating the licensing of GM crops, and will argue for local communities to be given the statutory right to create a 'GM-free' zone. In the UK, we will maintain a moratorium on the commercial planting of all GM crops that have the potential to contaminate non-GM and organic crops.

Protecting consumers.

- **Improving food safety and information.**

There need to be strong and transparent laws concerning food safety and labelling, so that consumers can be properly informed about what they eat, to help them tackle problems such as obesity. Liberal Democrats want to ensure that food standards and health agency work is not unnecessarily duplicated at national and European level, and encourage high standards.

- **Encouraging more competition in the European air transport market.**

Liberal Democrats want to overhaul rules on the allocation of landing slots to end the unfair advantage given to estab-

lished flag carriers. At the moment these airlines can obstruct access to the market for the newer budget airlines, which drives up prices for consumers. We will ensure that landing slots are auctioned on a fair and competitive basis.

- **Allowing effective action against foreign drivers who commit traffic offences on British roads.**

Co-operation between different countries' police forces needs to be improved so that the law is enforced across national boundaries.

Improving transport whilst protecting the environment.

- **Promoting fast and reliable rail links between Europe and the whole of the UK.**

Britain needs to be playing a full part in the Trans-European Transport Network (TEN-T). Among other things this is working to develop links be-

der for contracts in any EU country. As part of that, Liberal Democrats will seek to ensure that the UK government meets EU requirements on standards of quality, safety, affordability and accessibility, enforced by a strong UK regulator. This is in the clear interests of British passengers, and will help British companies to be successful when tendering abroad.

- **Reinforcing maritime safety around Britain's coasts.**

There need to be much more frequent and rigorous ship inspections in all EU ports. In addition, the EU should use its negotiating power within the International Maritime Organisation to negotiate a general revision of the Law of the Sea, so that coastal member states like the UK have the power to restrict shipping or introduce compulsory routing of ships in sensitive sea areas.

- **Reducing the environmental impact of maritime shipping.**

'Problems such as climate change, acid rain or the threat to the ozone layer cannot be effectively tackled by nations acting alone'

tween the Channel Tunnel and the rest of the UK. In particular this needs to give priority to linking peripheral parts of EU territory with the centre.

- **Reforming aviation taxation to support cleaner fuels and more efficient aircraft.**

This should be based on the "polluter pays" principle, where charges are based on the amount of pollution created rather than on a flat rate for all use. This encourages companies to use cleaner fuels and more efficient aircraft, and should be part of a longer-term EU strategy for reducing energy use and pollution.

- **Allowing British companies to tender for rail and public transport contracts in the rest of the EU.**

The laws need to be liberalised so that good companies can ten-

der for contracts in any EU country. As part of that, Liberal Democrats want to revise international and EU maritime liability rules in line with the "polluter pays" principle. In particular this should include banning ships from EU waters if they have insufficient insurance cover against maritime accidents. This is already the practice in the USA.

- **Creating a level playing field for British ports competing with continental ports.**

At the moment many other European countries have publicly owned ports, which get state aid. This gives them an unfair advantage when they compete with British ports for international trade.

These problems need to be addressed through greater financial transparency in the whole of the EU ports sector.



- Liberal Democrats support the principle of making the polluter pay

Justice and Security

Britain is less vulnerable to international crime because EU countries have worked together on justice and home affairs issues. We live in a safer country because the EU has enabled us to tackle international crime far more effectively than we could have done on our own.

This has involved co-operation on cross-border crime, terrorism and smuggling. There is much more that the EU can do to promote further co-operation and to tackle international crime, however, and Liberal Democrats regard this as essential work. We believe that member states should keep their own separate legal systems and values, but co-operation is still possible. While we should not look to harmonise our systems, we can gain mutual recognition of judicial decisions.

Before Britain joined the EU it took a lead in drafting the European Convention on Human Rights, through the Council of Europe. Building on that inheritance, the EU now plays a key role in developing and protecting human rights. However, while the movement of goods and capital across the EU is now fairly free, the movement of people is still more limited. It is in this area that the EU must now act.

Liberal Democrats want to make freedom of movement within the EU a reality, but this can only happen if the EU's external borders are effectively controlled. Existing procedures for cross-border law enforcement are lengthy and cumbersome, and they need modernisation. Progress towards a common asylum policy has also been too slow. Liberal Democrat priorities are:

Building effective external borders to create more freedom internally.

- **Making external EU border controls more effective.** There should be greater co-operation between police, immigration and customs officials. In particular the newest members of the EU should have the resources to police their borders

effectively. When we are satisfied that strong and effective EU external border controls are in place, it would be appropriate for Britain to take a full part in the EU system for allowing free movement of EU citizens (the Schengen Convention). Britain will then be able to benefit from greater co-operation within Schengen, such as British citizens having the benefit of passport-free movement.

- **Dealing with asylum seekers more quickly and effectively.** The EU needs common asylum procedures and an agreed policy for the just treatment of immigrants, so that wherever people arrive they are assured of fair treatment, and so that the system will be more easily understood. This must include fair sharing of responsibility between European countries. EU development and foreign policies should focus on reducing

poverty, conflict and human rights abuses, so that more people will feel safe to stay in their country of origin. Liberal Democrats also believe that the EU should streamline migration procedures and permit reasonable levels of legal immigration in line with labour and skills demands.

Preventing cross-border crime and catching international criminals.

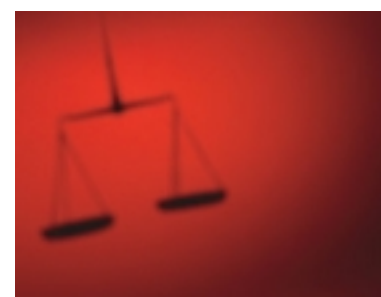
- **Tackling cross-border crime.** This requires good co-operation between the national police and security forces. But Liberal Democrats also want to strengthen Europol's resources, effectiveness and accountability, as laid down in the draft Constitution. Europol should not have powers of arrest, but it should act as a coordinating and investigative body that works with national police forces to ensure cross-border justice. It should also support the work of "Eurojust" in coordinating prosecutions of major cross-border crimes, including fraud against the EU budget.

- **Make more effective justice and home affairs decisions.** We will work to simplify procedures on justice and home affairs where the EU has a role in this area. The new Constitution rightly gives the European Par-

liament a joint role with the Council of Ministers, so that there will be greater democratic accountability than at present. States should retain their own legal systems and values, but we want to see greater legal cooperation, including in the area of criminal law. We support the need for basic standards relating to defendants' rights and legal aid, and recognise the value of making sure that major crimes such as drug trafficking are dealt with in a similar way across the EU.

- **Tackling the problems caused by the drugs trade.**

To support this closer co-operation it is important that member states take similar approaches to major crimes such as drug trafficking. Although some member states employ more liberal policies to drugs than others, no member state can tolerate the criminal gangs that profit from the drugs trade. Many international gangs take advantage of different laws to base their operations in countries with looser regulations, but sell their drugs across the EU. Therefore, there needs to be a Europe-wide review to assess the effectiveness of current policies and to look at areas for improvement. Liberal Democrats also want the EU to lead the debate at a UN level for reforming international drug agreements, so that countries can liberalise their laws on less harmful drugs and take the trade away from gangsters.



liament brings forward proposals to extend the law to new 'timeshare' products which currently avoid existing legislation and specifically to deal with behaviour by sales representatives which involves harassment, coercion or misleading claims.

Increasing the freedom of EU citizens across Europe

- **Work to tackle discrimination and harassment across Europe.**

This is a major and growing area of EU achievement. Supplementing the guarantees in the Charter of Fundamental Rights, existing EU directives on equal opportunities, and anti-discrimination relating to gender, race, disability, age, religion and sexual orientation should be implemented across the EU to ensure the same fundamental rights for all the people of Europe in every EU country, as the Constitution so provides. But there is also a need for further action by the EU. Many policies do not affect women and men equally, or indeed other social groups, so all

'We live in a safer country because Europe has enabled us to tackle international crime far more effectively than we could have done on our own'

- **Working against the trafficking of people.**

All countries should fight this lucrative criminal business by criminalising the traffickers, strengthening legislation and international co-operation and better protecting the victims. The EU should also give aid to the countries of origin, so that the poverty, gender inequality and corruption which makes people desperate enough to put themselves in the hands of traffickers can be eased.

- **Protecting people who buy timeshare holiday homes.**

With increased travel and holidaying throughout Europe, timeshare related problems are still the biggest source of cross-border legal problems which people get involved in. Although the first EU Timeshare Directive helped greatly, it is clear that more action is still needed; specifically Liberal Democrats would insist that the Commission

policies should assess their impact on equal opportunities. There should be new directives on equal treatment of men and women, going further than current rules which only cover workplaces. There should be equal rights for people with disabilities across the EU through the adoption of a specific European Disability Directive based on Article 13 of the 1997 Amsterdam Treaty, covering all areas of discrimination, not just in the employment field.

- **Ensuring civil liberties are not sacrificed in the fight against terrorism.**

It is perfectly possible to be both tough on terrorism and true to the treaties the UK has signed on citizens' rights. Liberal Democrats would argue for more forceful monitoring of human rights standards in the EU, and for better enforcement of the European guarantees of fundamental human rights.



Photo: Simon Rix

Peace and Influence

Above all else, the European Union was established to guarantee the peace and stability of Europe. After half a century of turmoil during which two world wars tore apart the fabric of western Europe, European nations decided to create a more concrete peace, cementing the bricks of NATO co-operation with the mortar of the EU. This co-operation and the mutual interest fostered by the EU has made war between the member states unthinkable.

The EU's role as a guarantor of peace has been particularly important since the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989, including supporting many of the former Communist countries to introduce democracy. The EU is playing the key role in rebuilding the war-torn Balkans, and the enlargement of the EU will consolidate greater security across the whole of Europe.

The EU needs the ability to act internationally, and to use its huge economic, technological, military and political resources to build stability, prosperity and democracy in the wider world. The EU should play a major role in developing international law, in the reform of the United Nations and in worldwide humanitarian and development work. To achieve this, substantial reforms to the EU itself are necessary.

In order to establish and increase its influence for the good of the whole of Europe, the EU needs to have agreed positions on foreign, security and defence issues. This does not

mean forcing any country to be involved in something it doesn't agree with. We do not advocate a single foreign, defence or security policy which is binding on all member

states. However, where member states do agree they can achieve far more by working in common, and there need to be systems in place to allow them to do that effectively.

Making European action more effective.

- **Helping countries to work together on foreign policy.**

At the moment there are too many foreign policy roles within EU structures. The new Constitution provides that the roles of the Council's High Representative and the Commissioner for External Relations should be merged. The new High Representative would be more able to co-ordinate the EU's policies towards the rest of the world, and should be accountable to the European Parliament and the Council, with a seat in the Commission. No country would be committed to action it disagreed with, however, and the decision to commit military forces must always remain the responsibility of the individual member state.

- **Ensuring agreed foreign policy is more effectively implemented.**

Once EU countries have agreed a course of action, it is important that action is taken quickly and effectively. The draft Constitution lays down that a new executive agency should assist in the coordination, development and implementation of the EU's foreign and security policy, answerable to the High Representative. The agency would include all overseas EU missions

‘Europe should work with the US to improve relations so that they can co-operate on common threats, and to try to persuade the US to ratify key environmental agreements, such as Kyoto’

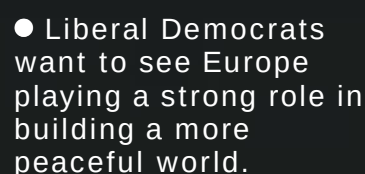
‘Above all else, the European Union was established to guarantee the peace and stability of Europe’

and all development operations, and would co-operate with others as necessary.

- **Increasing the EU's defence capability.**

The EU must pay its way and become a more responsible partner of the US. Liberal Democrats support the new Constitution which would strengthen the EU's defence role within NATO, and increase co-operation on areas such as research, procurement, logistics and support capabilities. This would bring savings to all countries, as well as making the EU more effective.





The EU is the largest donor of world aid, far ahead of the US or Japan. This is a major achievement, and Liberal Democrats want to build on that. However, the current aid bureaucracy in the EU is inefficient and skewed towards the wrong priorities. Therefore we want to target aid towards sustainable poverty alleviation, and streamline EU procedures relating to aid. The EU should assist in programmes to develop democracy in developing countries, and should ensure that poorer countries are able to benefit from access to markets

- **Make international development the external priority for the next British presidency of the EU.** When the UK assumes the presidency of the EU and the G8 in 2005, we will assess all decisions for their international development impact, so that the impact on developing countries is positive or at worst neutral. In any discussions relating to external affairs, international development should be a priority because of its implications for the environment, security and trade.

Europe and North America are the world's richest and most de-

veloped continents, and therefore they have a responsibility to work together within the United Nations for the benefit of the wider world. European and US interests are generally closely aligned, despite recent disagreements, and the EU should continue to develop itself as a partner rather than a rival to the US. The EU has many strengths to bring to the table in the management of world affairs, not least the euro, the aid budget and the pre-eminent role in trade. The EU should work with the US to improve relations so that they can co-operate within NATO on a common response to the common threats we face, and also try to persuade the US to ratify key environmental agreements, such as the Kyoto Protocol.

‘ The EU should play a major role in the reform of the United Nations and in worldwide development work ’

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